

Editorial

When Two Elephants Fight...

There has been significant growth in the online storage space in the last few years—with email storage going unlimited, multiple file hosting, large sub-hosting sites, etc. A key driver to this revolutionary growth is probably the increase in file sizes of music and video files that are largely being disseminated through the Internet. Look at the popularity of social sites like YouTube and Rediff iShare.

Look at the growing storage in e-mails today. Google's Gmail offers over 7 GB of email storage space, and it's ever increasing! You can also get an additional 10 GB at \$20/year to 400GB at \$500/year if you want.

Last year, Microsoft's Hotmail, which was the last to respond to the e-mail storage space wars, increased to 5 GB. They also offer extra storage at a cost to the consumer. On the lines of Google's online storage, Microsoft offers free storage through its hosting service called Windows Live SkyDrive, a password-protected online file storage with an option for it to be shared with other people. It now offers 5 GB of storage space. Earlier this service was available in Beta with a 1 GB storage cap—only in the US, the UK, and India post the first version that was a 500 MB online storage drive for US and UK only.

Do you see what's happening here? There is yet another Google-Microsoft war brewing. Both giants are expecting users to use more and more of their online storage services. The e-mail part is perceivable. Both Gmail and Hotmail have tens or hundreds millions using the service. Both are available in tonnes of languages, with exceptional features that tend to lure users—geeks, power users and amateurs—to get hooked on.

In my case, I even use Picasa Web albums and have some storage in SkyDrive as well. But are users ever going to choose these free storage options as their main storage mediums? I doubt it. Not because we aren't mature enough to do so, but because we do not trust those who are providing these services.

Both the giants have pulled back services—denying features that were earlier available to users. Google pulled the plug on the DTO/DTR (download-to-own/download-to-rent) portion of Google Video last year, and sent its users a \$2 Google Checkout bonus that can be redeemed at their online stores. Microsoft pulled off the WebDAV functionality from Hotmail that allowed user e-mails to be downloaded locally via desktop e-mail clients.



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The move to charge users for online storage would take some time to take off. In India it doesn't seem like people would pay for extra storage—and that too online. But you never know, as users become more and more Web-enabled, there is a good opportunity in the online storage market. Another reason is: trusting a free service with your important documents and files. I would rather store it on my own desktop storage—hard drive, DVD, etc. I even store some on my email—as a backup, like sending files to myself, etc. I would probably only use the online storage as a backup of my backup.

However, if companies like Google and Microsoft are at war to establish their supremacy, there is every possibility that the poor user could either be the beneficiary or the loser—more likely the loser. Haven't you heard of the saying, when two elephants fight, it is always the poor ant that gets squashed.

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